

Condemned to Be Free: Sartre on Bad Faith and Radical Responsibility

An original lesson plan inspired by **Christian J. Onof's** the Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Jean-Paul Sartre's Existentialism. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Christian J. Onof. Explore the original course: <https://iep.utm.edu/sartre-ex/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

60 minutes

TOPICS

Existentialism

“Sartre claims human beings have no fixed nature to fall back on and are therefore 'condemned to be free,' fully responsible for what they make of themselves — is this picture of freedom liberating, or is it too demanding a burden to actually live by?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Sartre's claim that 'existence precedes essence' and how it entails that human beings possess a radical, inescapable freedom not shared by manufactured objects.
- Identify and analyze Sartre's concept of bad faith using his café waiter example and at least one original example constructed by the student.
- Evaluate Sartre's claim that we are fully responsible for our choices — and even, in a sense, for our emotional reactions — by applying it to a contemporary case of someone denying their own freedom.

Materials Needed

- Excerpt handout: a short passage on 'existence precedes essence' and a paraphrased version of Sartre's café waiter example from Being and Nothingness
- Bad-faith scenario cards depicting people using various excuses to deny their freedom
- Whiteboard for the hook activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Paper-Cutter and the Human

8 min

Describe Sartre's contrast between a paper-cutter, whose purpose is fully decided by its maker before it exists, and a human being. Ask: does anyone or anything decide your purpose before you're born, the way a manufacturer decides a paper-cutter's purpose? Collect initial answers, and note any disagreement about whether biology, culture, or God might play that role.

Direct Instruction: Existence Precedes Essence and Radical Freedom

15 min

Introduce Sartre's core claim: for humans, existence precedes essence — we simply exist first, with no predetermined nature, and only create our 'essence' through the choices we actually make over a lifetime. Explain why Sartre takes this to mean freedom is not just something we have but something we cannot escape — even refusing to choose is itself a choice — which is the sense behind his famous claim that we are 'condemned to be free.'

Direct Instruction and Text Analysis: The Waiter and Bad Faith

17 min

Introduce bad faith using Sartre's café waiter, who moves and speaks with exaggerated precision, playing at being a waiter as though it were a fixed role determining his every action, rather than a free choice he continually renews. Explain that bad faith is a way of fleeing the anxiety of freedom by pretending to be a fixed thing (a role, a type, a nature) instead of acknowledging oneself as an ongoing, self-making freedom. Have students, in pairs, brainstorm one modern example of someone acting like the waiter.

Small-Group Case Analysis

13 min

Distribute the bad-faith scenario cards (a person who says 'I can't help it, that's just how I am,' someone who blames an assigned social role for a hurtful choice, someone who claims they 'had no choice' in a decision that in fact had alternatives). In groups, students identify the bad-faith move in each scenario and rewrite the person's excuse as an honest acknowledgment of their actual freedom and responsibility.

Closure

7 min

Return to the essential question. Ask for a show of hands: is Sartre's picture of total, inescapable freedom and responsibility ultimately liberating or exhausting? Ask one or two students on each side to justify their answer in a sentence.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is it really true that 'refusing to choose is itself a choice,' or are there situations where someone genuinely has no freedom at all, contrary to Sartre's claim?
- 2 Sartre's waiter is criticized for playing his role too perfectly — but isn't some degree of playing a role (a professional, a student, a sibling) just a normal and even necessary part of functioning in society, rather than bad faith?
- 3 If you are responsible even for your emotional reactions, as Sartre suggests, how would that change the way we usually excuse people by saying 'they couldn't help how they felt'?
- 4 Does Sartre's claim that there is no human nature apply equally to everyone, or do factors like a person's circumstances, body, or upbringing (what Sartre calls facticity) meaningfully limit how much freedom they actually have?
- 5 Is total, radical freedom actually good news, as Sartre insists it should be interpreted, or does his own description of it as 'condemnation' suggest even he saw it as at least partly a burden?

Assessment

Students write a short response constructing their own original example of bad faith (distinct from the waiter and from the scenario cards used in class), explaining specifically what excuse or fixed role the person is hiding behind, and rewriting the scenario to show what an authentic acknowledgment of freedom and responsibility would look like instead.

Extension Activity

Have students interview a family member or friend about a significant decision they once described as something they 'had no choice' about, and write a short analysis of whether Sartre would classify the decision as genuine bad faith or as a case involving real external constraint (facticity) that limited their freedom.

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